Membership of the Nuclear Suppliers Group is another indicator, as it reflects both India's arrival as a technology player and puts behind an obsolete framework. There would be many more occasions as new regimes, mechanisms and situations emerge.

When they look beyond just national interest, the two countries are indeed convergent in their effort to create a more balanced world. Be it in ensuring a strong and stable Russia, an Africa with more choices, or in preventing fundamentalist inroads into their heterogeneity, their interests overlap. At international negotiations, they sometimes find themselves on the same side of the argument. In June 2017, when the leaders of the two countries met at Astana, they reached consensus that at a time of global uncertainty, India-China relations are a factor of stability and in their relationship, India and China must not allow differences to become disputes. This revealed that despite all their divergences, there is a strategic maturity at work between them. That realization led to the Wuhan and Chennai Summits of 2018 and 2019 respectively. When shorn of their optics, both occasions were exercises in pure realism. The two nations discussed their future and that of the world very much with a sense of history. So, the world should hope that this perspective will find ways of getting beyond traditional limitations.

China's powerful rise is among the multiple factors that have led to a more uncertain world. As the politics of this era evolves, neither country has an interest in allowing the other to become a card against them. Making sure of that will depend on their own policies. One concern is that unlike on the rest of world, India's rise has been partly lost on a China that has been growing five times faster. It is up to India to ensure that its enhanced standing is given due weight. What was different at Wuhan and Chennai was not just the intensity of the engagement, but its setting against the evolving global backdrop in which both have such an important role. The practice of leaders of India and China having geopolitical conversations ceased many decades ago. Its resumption could well be a sign of a different future.

As India assesses the rise of China and weighs its own achievements, it should be objective about its prospects in comparison. To begin with, whatever political rhetoric in our country suggests from time to time, there are gaps in their comprehensive national power. We have yet to build some